

said. Most of his party colleagues refused to comment, stating that the party's West Bengal unit would decide on Nasreen's status. Even CPI(M) women's wing AIDWA did not have much to say about the writer, though it had criticised the fatwa issued against her in Bangladesh in the 1990s.

Leaders from other Left parties such as CPI, RSP and Forward Bloc feel that the chief minister could have handled the issue better. "The indecision of the state Government from the beginning of her stay in Kolkata has resulted in this situation," Forward Bloc National Secretary G. Devrajan said. After her book *Dwikhandito* was banned in West Bengal in 2003, CPI(M)'s explanation was that it was done for the "upkeep of democracy in Bengal". At that time, Bhattacharya was quoted by his party's mouthpiece *People's Democracy* as saying that he had read the book "many times over" and had then sought the opinion of an eminent writers' panel, which seemed to have shared the chief minister's sentiment. So, when Islamist organisations Milli Itle Parishad and Jamaat-e-Islami Hind got together to demand Nasreen's expulsion from West Bengal in September, CPI(M) leaders grew edgy. The violence in Nandigram angered the Muslims further as they were part of the battered population there.

The Congress-backed All-India Minority Forum was waiting in the wings for this opportunity. On November 22, it linked the Nasreen issue to Nandigram killings to embarrass CPI(M). Reactions to the riots were quick. Bhattacharya called out the army to contain a communal flare-up and the CPI(M)'s state Secretary and Politburo Member Biman Bose asked Nasreen to leave Kolkata. According to Hannan Mollah, CPI(M) MP from that state, "Fundamentalists along with political opponents of the Left Front hatched a conspiracy to hurt the Left's image." The Muslim vote in West Bengal amounts to 26 per cent.

YASBANT NEGI



SIPRA DAS



BJP

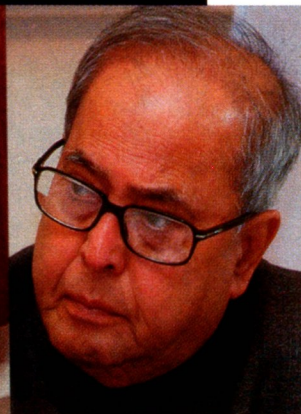
The party gleefully latches on to Nasreen's cause. **Narendra Modi** has offered her sanctuary in Gujarat while RSS and VHP have suddenly become the champions of free speech. Even **Vasundhara Raje** explained her refusal to let Nasreen stay on by claiming that the situation was still fragile after the Gujar-Meena riots. However, the writer was put up at the Rajasthan guest house in Delhi for a few days.

CONGRESS

The Congress doesn't know what to do with this political hot potato. **Pranab Mukherjee** (R) has told Parliament that while Nasreen can stay on, she should "not hurt the sentiments of our people". Welcoming her like Modi will antagonise the minority vote. Sundry Muslim Congressmen have voiced their apprehensions. Even the fiery **P.R. Dasmunshi** has refrained from castigating the Left while Congress spokesmen have attacked CPI(M) but done so with kid gloves on.



SUMETINDER SINGH



SIPRA DAS

Already on the defensive after Nandigram, CPI(M) is in a hurry to appease the Muslim voters as fast as it can. The Jamait-e-Ulema-e-Hind, a previously unknown outfit that has sprung to prominence in the wake of Nandigram, has long-term plans to cash in on the state's Muslims.

For outfits like the All India Minority Forum and the Furfurasharif Muzadeddia Anath Foundation—whose rally ignited the backlash in Kolkata leading to Nasreen's deportation—the writer is an ideal cause. For CPI(M), which has already lost the confidence of a huge chunk of Kolkata's middle class and a section of the rural voters, its biggest strength, after Nandigram, Muslims are too important to be ignored. While the party was successful in avoiding communal undertones to the Rizwanur Rahman case, the Nasreen issue has much bigger dimensions. CPI(M) was apprehensive about the writer after she was attacked in Hyderabad earlier this year. The Bhattacharya Government not only decided to confine her to her house, it also asked the then Kolkata police commissioner, Prasun Mukherjee, to put pressure on her to leave the city.

Finally, when parts of Kolkata burned, in true communist tradition, the Bhattacharya Government "exiled" her to Jaipur, which was not a bad destination for the writer after all. In Nasreen's words, it was one shock after another. "Hardly any security. Only a car came to pick me up. The driver dumped me at Shikha Hotel. The Rajasthan Police, it seemed, had no idea about my whereabouts. They were informed only after I took the flight. By then media had surrounded the hotel. At about midnight, the Rajasthan Police personnel knocked on my hotel room door. I was told about the impending law and order problem in the state and was told that I shouldn't stay there. Early in the morning, the police came. I thought they